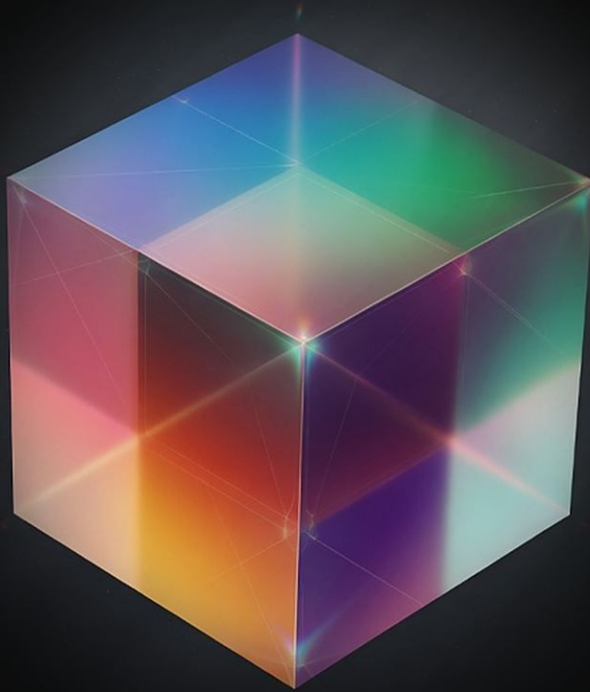




LEADERSHIP IS LEARNABLE

The Super-Cube[®] Leadership Model

Igniting Africa's potential and
accelerating humanity's progress

 Choices  Principles  Mental  Emotional  Physical  Spiritual

Dr Craig R. Muller

Based on doctoral research · University of KwaZulu-Natal



The Super-Cube® Leadership Model

Igniting Africa's potential and
accelerating humanity's progress

 Choices  Principles  Mental  Emotional  Physical  Spiritual

*A human-centric blueprint for developing leaders who transform individuals,
teams, organisations and society*

Dr Craig R. Muller

Based on doctoral research at the University of KwaZulu-Natal
Founder, Big Five Group

The Super-Cube® Leadership Model

Igniting Africa's potential and accelerating humanity's progress

© 2026 Dr Craig R. Muller. All rights reserved.

Free digital edition. This book is free to download at super-cube.me and bigfivegroup.africa/leadership. No part of it may be reproduced, stored or transmitted in any form without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations with acknowledgement. You are warmly invited to share the official download links.

About the stories. The stories in this book are illustrative composites drawn from patterns observed across African organisations. Names and details are illustrative; they are not case reports.

About the figures. The model comes from Dr Muller's Doctor of Business Administration thesis (University of KwaZulu-Natal, December 2020; degree conferred 2021): an 18-item survey of 132 leaders, followed by in-depth interviews. The 28-question Super-Cube® questionnaire came later. The before-and-after gains in this book (+32.2% overall) come from the 12-week, accredited Super-Cube® leadership intervention (NQF levels 3–5) with leaders at Imana Foods and Kerry Foods, not from the thesis.

About the self-assessments. The self-assessments are reflective tools for personal growth. They are not the validated research instrument, and they are not a substitute for professional medical or psychological advice.

Big Five Group · *Feed. Educate. Empower.* Big Five Learn is the education division of Big Five Group.

Set in Inter and Source Serif.

Contents

	Dedication	6
	Foreword	7
01	The Leadership Imperative Why Africa holds the key to humanity's future	9
02	The Genesis of the Super-Cube® From thesis to transformation	12
03	Understanding the Cube The six dimensions of Super-Leadership	16
04 	Choices The courage to decide in the fog of uncertainty	20
05 	Principles The unshakeable compass	26
06 	Mental The strategic mind that sees around corners	31
07 	Emotional The heart that connects and inspires	36
08 	Physical The sustainable vessel for long-haul leadership	41
09 	Spiritual The purpose that transcends and sustains	46
10	From Self to Society Scaling the Super-Cube® across levels	51
11	Leaders for the Global Goals Why the world's to-do list needs leaders, and why we must build them	54
12	The Big Five Way Real-world application across Africa	59
13	Your Super-Cube® Action Plan Start today, lead tomorrow	61
	A Super-Cube® World Awaits	64

Resources and Next Steps	68
About the Author	70

DEDICATION

To every young African dreamer staring at the horizon, wondering whether the choices you make today can reshape tomorrow.

To the leaders who choose principle over gain, empathy over ego, and purpose over power.

And to the generations yet unborn: may the Super-Cube® light your path to a humanity that thrives together.

Dr Craig R. Muller

Foreword

Africa stands at a pivotal crossroads. With the world's youngest population, vast natural resources and an entrepreneurial spirit forged in resilience, Africa holds the keys to humanity's next chapter. Yet leadership capacity remains the missing link — the bridge between potential and progress.

When I first encountered Craig Ross Muller's Super-Cube® Leadership Model during his doctoral research, I knew we had something extraordinary. Here was not another imported Western framework, but a homegrown, empirically validated system born from the realities of African business — tested in the crucible of fast-moving consumer goods networks facing skills shortages, corruption pressures and rapid growth.

What makes the Super-Cube® revolutionary is its elegant simplicity wrapped in profound depth. Six interconnected dimensions — Choices, Principles, Mental, Emotional, Physical and Spiritual — orbit the central “You”. It acknowledges that leadership is largely developable through deliberate practice, not some mystical birthright. It integrates the best of global theory with African wisdom, from Ubuntu's relational harmony to the pragmatic demands of building supply chains that feed nations.

At Big Five Group Africa, we have adopted the Super-Cube® as the cornerstone of our leadership development programmes. From training youth agribusiness entrepreneurs in Kenya and Tanzania to equipping peacebuilders in the Democratic Republic of Congo, we see its power daily. Young leaders who once felt powerless now make wiser choices, lead with empathy, sustain their energy and align their work with a higher purpose.

This book is more than a manual. It is a call to action. A blueprint for anyone — whether in a village cooperative, a corporate boardroom in Lagos, a start-up in Nairobi or a policy office in Addis Ababa — who

wants to accelerate not just their own leadership, but the collective progress of humanity.

The challenges are immense: food insecurity affecting hundreds of millions of Africans, youth unemployment rates that threaten stability, climate shocks that test our resilience. But the Super-Cube® offers hope grounded in evidence. It has been rigorously validated through extensive research in African organisational contexts. It works in the real world of African enterprise.

Read this book with an open heart and a notebook ready. Apply its principles. Build your own Super-Cube®. Then help others build theirs. Together, we will not just develop leaders — we will forge a future where Africa leads the world in human flourishing.

Dr Housainou Taal

Director, African Leadership Institute | Advisor to Big Five Group



CHAPTER 01

The Leadership Imperative

Why Africa holds the key to humanity's future

Africa is the youngest continent on Earth. The choices its young people make — and the leaders who shape them — will ripple far beyond its borders. Harnessed through wise leadership, that energy could drive extraordinary progress. Squandered, it risks instability that touches every continent.

The challenges are familiar: hunger, youth unemployment, a changing climate, institutions still maturing, skills mismatches alongside abundant talent, and the long shadows of corruption and conflict.

Yet Africa is not waiting to be saved. It is rising. Farmers are restoring tired soils. Mobile technology is leapfrogging old infrastructure. A new generation of entrepreneurs is solving local problems in ways the world is beginning to notice.

The missing ingredient is leadership — at every level. Not the lone, charismatic hero of old myths, but a new kind of leader: someone who makes wise choices under pressure, stands on unshakeable principles, thinks strategically, connects emotionally, sustains their physical energy and draws strength from a deep sense of purpose. I call this person a *Super-Cube® leader*.

FIELD SNAPSHOT · AUGUST 2024

Young people want a model to steer by. 33 Grade 12 boarders at a leading high school in South Africa answered a leadership questionnaire after a brief Super-Cube® leadership intervention.

94%

believe leadership is important

88%

would like to develop their leadership using a scientific approach

0%

had a leadership model they actually used

Self-reported answers, not assessment scores or before-and-after results. The school and learners are not named.

Every one of them said the choices they make in life are important, and every one said principles are important. Yet asked which leadership approach they use, none could name one. The wish to grow is there; the missing piece is a model. That gap is why this book exists. The Super-Cube® is such a model: theoretically grounded, empirically validated (Chapter 2), and with a programme written for adolescents.

Leadership is learnable

This is not wishful thinking. My doctoral research (Doctor of Business Administration thesis, University of KwaZulu-Natal, 2020) used mixed methods — surveys followed by in-depth interviews with senior leaders — inside a real African business network. It confirmed what many of us suspected: leadership skills are not fixed traits. They are largely developable through deliberate, whole-person practice.

The model draws on the best of leadership science — trait theory, relational leadership, emotional intelligence and principle-centred leadership — rooted in African realities and in Martin Buber's I-Thou philosophy: seeing every person as a whole human being, never as an object to be used.

The leadership crisis is real. The opportunity is historic. The tools are in your hands.

This book is an invitation not to passive reading, but to active practice. Every chapter ends with a short practice and one thing you can do today. Keep a notebook close. Let us begin.

PRACTICE

Write one sentence in your notebook: "The leadership I most want to grow in the next 90 days is ..." Date it. You will come back to it in Chapter 13.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Ask one person you lead, or learn alongside: "What is one thing I could do to lead you better?" Then simply listen.



CHAPTER 02

The Genesis of the Super-Cube®

From thesis to transformation

The Super-Cube® did not begin in an ivory tower. It began in the warehouses, boardrooms and rural supply routes of African business networks working through the realities of emerging markets.

As a practitioner and researcher, I saw the leadership bottleneck first-hand. Brilliant young managers struggled with ethical dilemmas under pressure. Visionary entrepreneurs burnt out. Teams with immense potential fractured over poor emotional intelligence and misaligned principles. The toll was counted in stalled careers, unfulfilled potential and communities that stayed hungry.

Western leadership models have much to teach, but they often felt imported — like shoes that didn't quite fit the African foot. They favoured individual heroism over collective harmony, cognitive skill over whole-person well-being, and short-term results over lasting purpose. Africa needed something tested in its own soil.

The question

My doctoral research asked a simple but searching question: *What integrated framework can develop leadership skills in complex African business networks — and how can it scale from the individual to the industry?*

What the research revealed

Surveys, followed by in-depth interviews with senior decision-makers, surfaced clear themes. Mental capabilities featured most prominently, followed closely by emotional intelligence, then principles, spiritual purpose and choices. The physical dimension was mentioned least of all — exposing a gap in self-care that quietly undermines even the most talented leaders.

The shape crystallised naturally: six faces, each a developable dimension, interconnected and centred on the individual — *You*. Not a hierarchy, but a living system, like the ecosystems of the savanna or the resilient supply chains we studied.

Two foundations

Philosophy. Martin Buber's I-Thou describes leadership as mutual recognition, where leaders and followers see each other fully and never as a means to an end. It resonates deeply with Ubuntu: *I am because we are.*

Learning theory. Knud Illeris showed that we learn across three dimensions: content (what we understand), incentive (what motivates us) and interaction (who we learn with). Leadership is practised in relationships, reflected on in solitude, and sustained by physical and spiritual vitality.

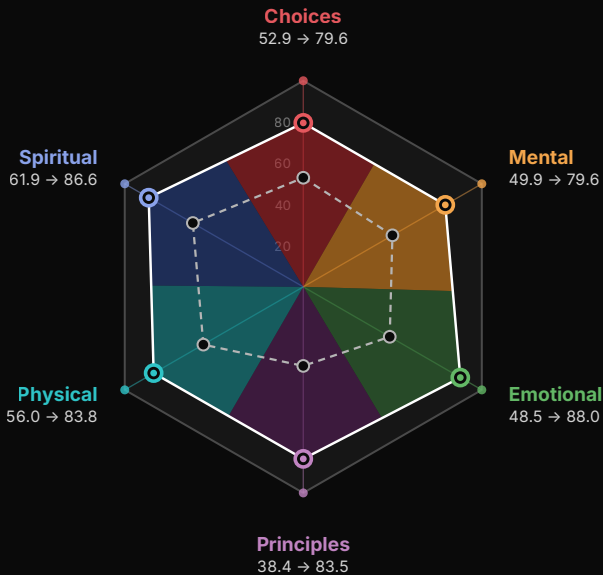
From model to practice

Models mean nothing without application. In a 12-week, accredited Super-Cube® leadership intervention, leaders at Imana Foods and Kerry Foods were assessed on every face before and after the course. Practised deliberately, every face grew. In the radar below, the dashed inner shape is where they started and the solid outer shape is where they finished: Principles, which started lowest, moved furthest, and Emotional finished highest.

MEASURED GROWTH · BEFORE AND AFTER TWELVE WEEKS

+32.2%

average rise in assessment scores across the six faces (percentage points), start to end of course



- - - Before (dashed) — After (solid, face colours)

+26.6%

Choices

+45.1%

Principles

+29.7%

Mental

+39.5%

Emotional

+27.7%

Physical

+24.6%

Spiritual

Real results, drawn in the style of the growth radar on super-cube.me. Average assessment scores per face (per cent) before and after the 12-week accredited Super-Cube® leadership intervention (NQF levels 3–5) with leaders at Imana Foods and Kerry Foods; gains in percentage points. Group averages, not one learner's report.

PRACTICE

Think of the best leader you have known. Which of the six faces did they show most strongly? Which was missing? Write two lines on each.

☐ **ONE THING TODAY**

Notice one decision you make on autopilot today. Don't change it yet — just notice it.



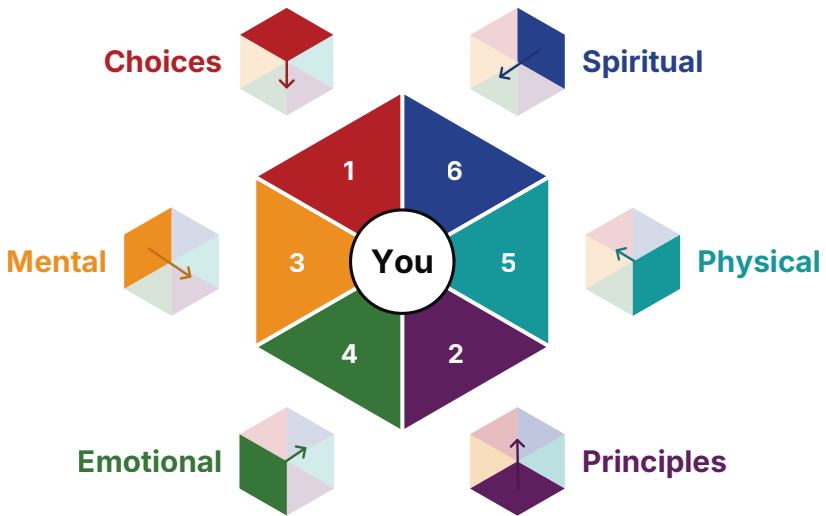
CHAPTER 03

Understanding the Cube

The six dimensions of Super-Leadership

Picture a cube. Not a static block, but a living, glowing structure floating in the space between potential and reality. At its centre stands a person — you. Each of the six faces is a dimension of leadership. Developed in balance, they create a leader of extraordinary impact.

The Super-Cube® is not a checklist or a personality test. It is a dynamic system. Strengthen one face and the others gain stability. Neglect one and the whole structure wobbles. As with a Rubik's Cube, mastery comes through deliberate turns: daily choices, consistent practices, reflective growth.



The Super-Cube®: six interconnected faces, with you at the centre.



1 Choices

Decision-making under ambiguity: moral judgement, risk assessment and the courage to choose the harder right over the easier wrong.



2 Principles

The ethical foundation: integrity, transparency, accountability and contextual wisdom — so that power serves people, not the reverse.



3 Mental

Strategic thinking, problem-solving, vision and the application of knowledge: the engine of innovation for Africa's leapfrog opportunities.



4 Emotional

Emotional intelligence in full — perceiving, using, understanding and managing emotions. Empathy, inspiration and relationships: the glue of teams.



5 Physical

The often-neglected foundation: energy, fitness, nutrition, resilience and rest. Sustainable leadership needs a sustainable vessel.



6 Spiritual

Purpose, meaning and alignment with something larger than self — the “why” that sustains the “how”, whether rooted in faith, humanism or service.

The faces work together

These six are not silos. A principled choice (Principles and Choices), made with emotional awareness (Emotional) and strategic foresight (Mental), sustained by physical energy (Physical) and higher purpose (Spiritual), multiplies its impact.

Five levels of impact

The cube operates at five progressive levels, from your own daily practice to humanity's progress. Chapter 10 shows how to move outward.

1. **Individual** — your personal Super-Cube®: self-awareness and daily practice.
2. **Team or business** — embedding the model in one organisation or group.
3. **Network** — scaling across supply chains and partnerships.

4. **Industry or sector** — influencing wider systems, such as African agribusiness or manufacturing.
5. **Society, continent and world** — contributing to humanity's progress: the ultimate ripple.

How to use the next six chapters

Each face chapter follows the same rhythm: why it matters, the approach, how it grows, six practices, an illustrative story and a self-assessment. The self-assessments are reflective tools for your personal growth; they are not the validated instrument used in the doctoral research.

WORKBOOK · YOUR FIRST SNAPSHOT

FACE	TODAY (1-10)	DAY 30 (1-10)
 Choices		
 Principles		
 Mental		
 Emotional		
 Physical		
 Spiritual		

Strongest face: _____ Weakest face: _____

PRACTICE

Before reading on, fill in the snapshot above by instinct, rating each face from 1 to 10. Circle your strongest face and your weakest. Your weakest face is your biggest opportunity.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Explain the six faces to one other person. Teaching is the fastest way to learn.



CHAPTER 04 · FACE 1 OF 6

Choices

The courage to decide in the fog of uncertainty

“The history of free men is never really written by chance but by choice — their choice.”

— Dwight D. Eisenhower

In the markets of Lagos and the boardrooms of Johannesburg, leaders face a daily stream of choices where the right path is shrouded in ambiguity. A supplier offers a “facilitation fee”. A promising hire has connections but questionable integrity. A quick win conflicts with long-term community impact. A regulatory grey area tempts a shortcut that could save the quarter but wound the soul of the enterprise. This is the lived reality of African leadership.

The Choices face is your decision-making intelligence: the capacity to navigate moral complexity, weigh risk wisely and choose with courage and clarity.

Why Choices matter

Where institutions are still maturing and economic pressure blurs the line between survival and integrity, wise choices are the foundation of prosperity and social cohesion. Every choice strengthens or erodes the trust that communities, employees and future generations rely on. Leaders who choose the harder right over the easier wrong attract talent and loyalty, and show that success and integrity belong together. A single compromised choice can unravel years of good work.

We are not purely rational. Jonathan Haidt’s *The Righteous Mind* shows that intuition — the “elephant” — usually leads, and reasoning — the “rider” — follows. Where relationships carry great weight, a choice that breaks the unspoken contract of Ubuntu reaches far beyond the balance sheet.

Daniel Kahneman’s *Thinking, Fast and Slow* adds a warning: under pressure, fatigue or stress we default to fast, intuitive “System 1” thinking — fine for routine decisions, risky for novel or ethically murky ones. The Choices face trains you to switch to slower “System 2”: to pause, gather perspectives, and choose with head and heart.

The Super-Cube® approach

The Super-Cube® does not ask you to become a saint or to ignore commercial reality. It asks something more demanding, and more African: to see every stakeholder through the I-Thou lens — a whole person with hopes, fears and dignity, never a means to an end.

So beyond “Is it legal?” and “Does it make commercial sense?”, the Super-Cube® leader asks two more questions: *What story will this choice tell about who we are becoming?* And *how will it ripple through the web of relationships that sustains our community?*

How it grows

Three connected habits build this face. **The Pause** creates space between stimulus and response. **Perspective-taking** seeks the humanity in every stakeholder. **Post-choice reflection** learns from every decision without self-condemnation. Over time they rewire your defaults, so wise choosing becomes natural.

It is not about perfection. It is about the courage to pause.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

The choice that defined who we are

A young procurement manager in a Zambian agribusiness faces a cash crunch, and a key supplier offers him a facilitation fee to speed up payment. He pauses. He maps the stakeholders: the supplier’s family, the smallholder farmers whose deliveries would stop if the supplier collapsed, his own team, the organisation’s reputation and his own integrity.

Instead of taking the fee, he helps the supplier reach legitimate financing through a community lending scheme. The relationship deepens, and the supplier becomes a champion of ethical practice. Years later,

the story is told to every new employee as “the choice that defined who we are”.

A composite drawn from patterns observed across African organisations; names and details are illustrative.

Six practices

1 The Daily Pause 10 MINUTES · EVERY MORNING

Before the day’s decisions begin, sit quietly and ask: *Which choices today might test my values? What would the wisest version of me choose?* You will recognise ethical moments when they arrive.

2 The Stakeholder Map EVERY SIGNIFICANT DECISION

On paper, map everyone the choice affects — not only those in the room, but those downstream: the smallholder farmer in your supply chain, the child whose parent works in your factory, the community beside your operations. For each, ask: *If I were in their place, how would I want to be treated?* The map reveals options you would otherwise miss.

3 The Legacy Question WEEKLY · SUNDAY EVENING

Write your answer: *If my children or grandchildren read about this week’s decisions in twenty years, what would they think of me? What story am I writing with my life?*

4 Dilemma Rehearsal MONTHLY · WITH YOUR TEAM

Present a realistic but fictional dilemma — a kickback offered during a cash crunch, or pressure to overlook environmental standards to win a tender. Work through it: What are the facts? Who is affected? What do our principles demand? Which choice would we be proud to defend in public? You are building organisational muscle memory.

5 A Choice Mentor or Peer Circle MONTHLY

Meet someone who chooses with integrity under pressure and discuss real dilemmas in confidence: *What would you do, and why?* Or form a small peer circle, and hold one another accountable with compassion, not judgement.

6 The Quarterly Choice Audit EVERY THREE MONTHS

Review three to five significant choices. *What was the outcome — for results, relationships and my integrity? What would I do differently? What pattern do I see?* This is how experience becomes wisdom.

NOTES

WORKBOOK



Your Choices self-assessment

Rate each statement honestly from 1 (rarely true for me) to 10 (consistently true).

- | | | |
|----|---|----------------------|
| 1 | I pause and create space before high-stakes decisions, rather than reacting from pressure or emotion. | <input type="text"/> |
| 2 | I consider the impact of my choices on all stakeholders, including those without voice or power. | <input type="text"/> |
| 3 | I have the courage to say "no" to opportunities that compromise my values or the long-term health of my organisation and community. | <input type="text"/> |
| 4 | I seek diverse perspectives, especially from those who see the world differently or will be most affected. | <input type="text"/> |
| 5 | I treat every person involved as a whole human being (I-Thou), not as a means to an end. | <input type="text"/> |
| 6 | I learn from poor choices without harsh self-condemnation, and adjust my process. | <input type="text"/> |
| 7 | I consider not only what is legal and commercially sound, but what is right and what legacy I am creating. | <input type="text"/> |
| 8 | I explain my reasoning openly when my choices affect others. | <input type="text"/> |
| 9 | I feel at peace with my decisions, even difficult ones, because they align with my deepest values. | <input type="text"/> |
| 10 | I help others in my organisation develop their own capacity for wise choices. | <input type="text"/> |

Total (out of 100)

80–100

Exceptional. You are a model for others.

60–79

Strong foundation. Use the practices to go further.

Below 60

Needs intentional development. Start with the Daily Pause and the Stakeholder Map.

Date: _____ Retake on day 30: _____

PRACTICE

This week, use the Stakeholder Map on one real decision before you make it. Note one option it revealed that you had not seen.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Before your next important "yes", pause for sixty seconds and ask: *Who else does this touch?*

Measure and develop this face at super-cube.me · free baseline and growth report



CHAPTER 05 · FACE 2 OF 6

Principles

The unshakeable compass

“Be the change you wish to see in the world.”

— attributed to Mahatma Gandhi

We live on shifting sand: political winds that change with each election, volatile markets, online outrage that can destroy a reputation in hours, and the constant temptation to cut corners. Principles are the bedrock of lasting leadership.

The Principles face is your ethical infrastructure: integrity, transparency, accountability, fairness and contextual wisdom. It ensures that power, influence and success serve people rather than exploit them.

Why Principles matter

Ancient wisdom and modern corporate scandals teach the same lesson: without strong principles, even the most talented leaders eventually derail — and take their organisations and communities with them. Where principles are weak, corruption finds a foothold, toxic cultures grow and talent leaves. Where trust in institutions is fragile and the memory of exploitation runs deep, principled leadership is not a luxury. It is the precondition for progress.

Principles are not rules imposed from outside; they are the living expression of who we are. They answer one question: *When no one is watching and the easy path beckons, what do we choose?* From Ubuntu to the Akan principle of *Sankofa* — learning from the past to build the future — Africa is rich in this wisdom.

The Super-Cube® approach

Drawing on principle-centred leadership, the Super-Cube® treats principles not as a compliance checklist but as a living compass that always points to human dignity, mutual respect (I-Thou) and long-term flourishing.

These principles are *relational* — tested not only in the boardroom but in daily dealings with employees, suppliers, customers, regulators and communities — and *lived in context*, adapting to culture and pressure without compromising core integrity. When they are strong, ethical behaviour is rewarded, wrongdoing is addressed with fairness and com-

passion, and leaders find the courage to make unpopular but necessary decisions.

How it grows

Three connected practices build this face. **Clarification** names and internalises your core principles. **Alignment** ensures daily decisions and systems reflect them. **Accountability** creates relationships and structures that hold you to them, with compassion and rigour.

When no one is watching and the easy path beckons, what do we choose?

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

The burden that became a strength

In a post-conflict reconstruction initiative in the Democratic Republic of Congo, a young leader is pressured to divert resources to connected elites in exchange for political protection. The organisation's survival seems to hang in the balance.

Instead of compromising, he gathers his team and names their shared principles: transparency, fairness and service to the most vulnerable. Together they build a different path — public accountability, community oversight committees and partnerships with ethical funders. The road is harder and slower, but trust grows and the initiative becomes a reference point for integrity. “The principles that felt like a burden became our greatest strength,” he reflects. “They gave us the courage to innovate and the credibility to lead.”

A composite drawn from patterns observed across African organisations; names and details are illustrative.

Six practices

1 Principles Clarification ONE DAY, THEN YEARLY · PERSONAL AND TEAM

Set aside a day. Ask: *What do I stand for, whatever the price? Which values would I defend even if it meant losing a deal, a promotion or a relationship?* Write them simply. Then do the same with your team — not a compliance document, but a declaration of who you are.

2 The Weekly Alignment Check 15 MINUTES · EVERY FRIDAY

Review the week. *Where did I live my principles fully? Where did I compromise, rationalise or avoid? What pressures contributed?* Adjust course. This keeps principles alive instead of gathering dust in a policy manual.

3 The Transparency Audit QUARTERLY

Choose one area — procurement, hiring, reporting or community engagement. Are decisions documented and explainable? Are stakeholders informed? Can concerns be raised without fear of retaliation? Close the gaps. Transparency is the oxygen of trust.

4 Accountability Partners MONTHLY

Find one or two people with whom you can be completely honest, and ask: *Did I uphold my principles? Where did I fall short?* Build the same circles in your team; they counter the isolation that leads to compromise.

5 “What would my hero do?” DAILY

Choose a leader you admire — Nelson Mandela, a community elder, a business leader known for integrity. In a hard moment, ask: *What would they do? Which principle would they honour?*

6 Systemic Integrity ANNUALLY · ORGANISATION-WIDE

Principles are only as strong as the systems around them. If bonuses reward short-term results at the expense of integrity, change them. If performance reviews ignore ethical conduct, add it.

WORKBOOK



Your Principles self-assessment

Rate each statement honestly from 1 (rarely true for me) to 10 (consistently true).

1	I act in line with my stated values, even when it costs me personally or professionally.	
2	I create transparent systems and welcome scrutiny of my decisions and processes.	
3	I hold myself and others accountable with fairness, compassion and consistency.	
4	I adapt principles to context without compromising core integrity.	
5	I build cultures where ethical behaviour is rewarded and unethical behaviour is addressed constructively.	
6	I communicate my principles clearly and model them visibly, especially under pressure.	
7	I have structures in place (mentors, peer circles, audits) that hold me to my principles.	
8	I review and realign organisational systems (incentives, measures, policies) to support principled behaviour.	
9	I speak up when I see principles being compromised, even when it is uncomfortable or risky.	
10	I feel a deep sense of integrity and peace because my actions reflect my values.	
Total (out of 100)		

80–100

Exceptional. You are a model for others.

60–79

Strong foundation. Use the practices to go further.

Below 60

Needs intentional development. Start with Principles Clarification and the Weekly Alignment Check.

Date: _____ Retake on day 30: _____

PRACTICE

Write your five core principles on a single card. Carry it for a week, and read it before every significant meeting.

☐ **ONE THING TODAY**

Name one place where your stated values and your actual systems disagree. Write it down, and decide who you will talk to about it.

Measure and develop this face at super-cube.me · free baseline and growth report



CHAPTER 06 · FACE 3 OF 6

Mental

The strategic mind that sees around corners

“Imagination is more important than knowledge.”

— Albert Einstein

Africa's challenges are complex, adaptive and interconnected — exactly the conditions in which strong mental leadership shines. The Mental face covers cognitive intelligence, strategic thinking, problem-solving, vision and the application of knowledge. In the research interviews it featured more prominently than any other face: without clear, systems-level thinking, even the best intentions falter.

Why Mental matters

Climate change is colliding with food systems. Rapid urbanisation meets infrastructure gaps. Young people need work in largely informal economies. Technology can help whole nations leapfrog — or leave them behind. Leaders who see patterns, anticipate unintended consequences and craft coherent long-term visions are essential.

Mental leadership is not about the highest IQ or the most impressive degrees. It is the disciplined application of thinking to messy, real-world problems — the difference between reacting to each crisis and shaping the future. Its enemy is false certainty. Its tools are rigour, humility and creativity.

The Super-Cube® approach

The Super-Cube® combines cognitive science with African wisdom traditions that value deep reflection, storytelling and elders who see patterns across decades. It draws on *systems thinking* — seeing the whole rather than isolated parts — on *Sankofa*, learning from the past to build the future, and on cognitive psychology's insights into overcoming bias and building collective intelligence.

This is not cold rationality. It is thinking in service of humanity: clear, creative and courageous.

How it grows

The Mental face grows through *individual discipline* — reading, reflection and deliberate practice — and *collective processes*: diverse teams, structured dialogue and after-action reviews.

The best mental leaders are not the smartest in the room. They make the room smarter.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

From logistics to systems

A young agribusiness entrepreneur in Kenya is battling post-harvest losses that threaten her start-up. Better storage and faster transport help only a little.

Using the Weekly Systems Scan, she maps the whole picture: farmer practices, market timing, attitudes to “ugly” produce, weather patterns and what consumers want. The leverage point, she realises, is not logistics but perception and timing. She pivots to connecting farmers directly with city consumers through a mobile platform for “ugly but fresh” produce, with pricing that rewards quality and reduces waste. Losses fall and farmers benefit. “I thought I was in the logistics business,” she says. “I discovered I was in the systems-thinking business.”

A composite drawn from patterns observed across African organisations; names and details are illustrative.

Six practices

1 The Weekly Systems Scan 30–45 MINUTES · SUNDAY EVENING

Map one key challenge as a system: the people, processes, external forces, history and cultural norms involved. Where are the leverage points — small changes with big effects? Which assumptions limit our view? What would good look like in one, three and ten years? What unintended consequences might we be creating? Write it down; your strategic eyesight sharpens like a muscle.

2 Deep Reading and Synthesis AT LEAST THREE HOURS A WEEK

Read beyond industry reports: history, philosophy, biography, science and African literature. After each significant read, write one page: *What are the key insights? How do they connect to my work? Which assumptions do they challenge?*

3 Seek Different Perspectives ONGOING

If you are urban, spend time with rural farmers. If you work in the formal economy, engage the informal sector. Build dissent into meetings: *What are we missing? Who sees this differently?*

4 Scenario Planning QUARTERLY · WITH YOUR TEAM

Explore alternative futures: *What if climate shocks intensify? What if new technology disrupts our value chain? What if instability returns?* Develop a response to each, and expose blind spots in today's strategy.

5 After-Action Reviews WITHIN A WEEK OF EVERY MAJOR PROJECT

Gather the team and ask: *What did we intend? What actually happened? Why the gap? What will we do differently next time?* Record and share the learning, so experience becomes organisational wisdom.

6 Mental Model Mapping PERSONAL PRACTICE

Write down your assumptions about people, markets, power, change, Africa and success. Then ask: *Where might these be incomplete or out of date?* Thinking about your own thinking is the hallmark of advanced mental leadership.

NOTES

WORKBOOK



Your Mental self-assessment

Rate each statement honestly from 1 (rarely true for me) to 10 (consistently true).

1	I regularly step back to see the big picture, long-term patterns and systemic connections.	
2	I synthesise information from diverse sources to generate new insights and solutions.	
3	I communicate complex ideas simply and compellingly, in ways that inspire action.	
4	I anticipate unintended consequences and plan contingencies.	
5	I create space for deep thinking and reflection amid the daily whirlwind.	
6	I seek out and integrate diverse perspectives, especially those that challenge my own.	
7	I use structured processes (systems mapping, scenario planning, after-action reviews) to improve collective thinking.	
8	I read widely and deeply, constantly expanding my mental library.	
9	I help others develop their strategic and systems-thinking capacity.	
10	I feel confident navigating complexity and making sound judgements under uncertainty.	

Total (out of 100)

80-100

Exceptional. You are a model for others.

60-79

Strong foundation. Use the practices to go further.

Below 60

Needs intentional development. Start with the Weekly Systems Scan and After-Action Reviews.

Date: _____ Retake on day 30: _____

PRACTICE

Run one Weekly Systems Scan this Sunday on your biggest current challenge. Circle the single leverage point you will act on.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Ask one person who sees the world differently from you: "What am I missing?"

Measure and develop this face at super-cube.me · free baseline and growth report



CHAPTER 07 · FACE 4 OF 6

Emotional

The heart that connects and inspires

“One of the most difficult things to give away is kindness — it is usually returned.”

— Mark Ortman

Leadership is relational. No strategy succeeds without people who feel seen, valued and inspired. The Emotional face is emotional intelligence in its four branches — perceiving, using, understanding and managing emotions, as set out in the Mayer–Salovey–Caruso model. It was a prominent theme in the research, and it is the face that turns competent managers into leaders people want to follow.

+39.5%

Average improvement on the Emotional face in the 12-week Super-Cube® leadership intervention with Imana Foods and Kerry Foods.

Why Emotional matters

Where relationships come before transactions and trust is earned through care more than credentials, emotional intelligence is not a “soft skill”. It is strategic. Leaders who read the undercurrents in a room, bridge divides and manage their own reactions under pressure create places where people bring their whole selves to work.

When emotional intelligence is weak, talented people leave because they feel unseen, conflicts fester and people do the minimum. When it is strong, leaders build *psychological safety* — the shared belief that it is safe to take interpersonal risks — which Amy Edmondson’s research closely links to team learning and performance.

The Super-Cube® grounds emotional intelligence in Buber’s I–Thou: the capacity to see and honour the full humanity of every person. This is deeply African. It echoes the Zulu greeting *Sawubona* — “I see you” — and its reply, *Ngikhona* — “I am here”.

The Super-Cube® approach

This is not about manipulating emotions or suppressing authenticity. It is emotional intelligence in service of people and shared purpose — never ego or control.

How it grows

You develop this face by practising the four branches. **Perceive:** read emotional cues accurately. **Use:** let emotions sharpen thinking and communication. **Understand:** grasp emotional dynamics and their causes. **Manage:** regulate emotions in yourself and others constructively.

Emotional leadership begins with truly seeing.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

Seeing people, really seeing them

Amina leads a team in a Tanzanian agribusiness co-operative. Turnover is high and morale is low. Her team finds her distant and critical; she sees herself as professional and results-focused.

She starts the Daily Check-in and the Empathy Walk — and discovers that her team, mostly women from rural backgrounds, carry heavy loads balancing work, family and community. Her brisk style reads to them as a lack of care. She begins meetings with a genuine “How are you, really?”, adjusts workloads in planting season, and celebrates resilience as well as results. Over the following months people stay, energy returns and new ideas begin to flow. “I thought leadership was about driving performance,” she reflects. “It is about seeing people — really seeing them — and creating the conditions where they want to give their best.”

A composite drawn from patterns observed across African organisations; names and details are illustrative.

Six practices

1 The Daily Check-in 5 MINUTES · MORNING AND EVENING

Morning: What am I feeling? What might trigger me today? How do I want to show up? Evening: What did I feel? How did I handle it? What would I do differently?

2 The Empathy Walk WEEKLY · 15–20 MINUTES

Give one person — a team member, supplier or community member — your full presence. Listen without interrupting or planning your reply. Reflect back what you heard, including the feeling: “It sounds as if you’re excited about the new direction, and anxious about the uncertainty. Is that right?” Ask: “What would support look like for you right now?” Then follow up within 48 hours with one concrete action.

3 Conflict as Opportunity WHenever it arises

Resist the urge to avoid or dominate. Use LARA: Listen fully; Affirm the person’s perspective and feelings; Respond to their concerns; then Add your own view. Your team learns that conflict can strengthen relationships.

4 Emotional Data in Decisions BEFORE EVERY MAJOR DECISION

Ask: *What emotions are present in the room and among stakeholders? What undercurrent might the data miss? How will this land, and how do we address that?* Emotions are data, not noise.

5 Build Psychological Safety TEAM PRACTICE

Agree explicit norms: *We speak up when we see problems. We admit mistakes without fear. We ask when we don’t understand. We give feedback with care and receive it with openness.* Model them, especially when you are wrong.

6 A Regulation Toolkit PERSONAL MASTERY

Build a toolkit for intense moments: slow breathing (the 4-7-8 breath), movement, journaling, talking to someone you trust, a short walk outside. Practise when the stakes are low, so the tools are there when they are high. Channel emotion; don’t suppress it.

WORKBOOK



Your Emotional self-assessment

Rate each statement honestly from 1 (rarely true for me) to 10 (consistently true).

1	I accurately read others' emotions, even when they are unspoken or masked.	
2	I use emotional awareness to guide my thinking, communication and decisions.	
3	I understand complex emotional dynamics in individuals, teams and conflicts.	
4	I manage my own emotions well, especially under stress or provocation.	
5	I inspire and motivate others by connecting to their deeper aspirations and values.	
6	I create psychological safety, so people feel free to speak up, take risks and be themselves.	
7	I resolve conflicts constructively, leaving relationships stronger rather than damaged.	
8	I give and receive feedback with care, specificity and impact.	
9	I help others develop their emotional intelligence.	
10	I feel connected to the people I lead and find joy in seeing them grow.	
Total (out of 100)		

80-100

Exceptional. You are a model for others.

60-79

Strong foundation. Use the practices to go further.

Below 60

Needs intentional development. Start with the Daily Check-in and the Empathy Walk.

Date: _____ Retake on day 30: _____

PRACTICE

Do one Empathy Walk this week, and follow up within 48 hours with one concrete action.

☐ **ONE THING TODAY**

In your next conversation, name the feeling you hear before you respond: "It sounds as if you're ..."

Measure and develop this face at super-cube.me · free baseline and growth report



CHAPTER 08 · FACE 5 OF 6

Physical

The sustainable vessel for long-haul leadership

“Take care of your body. It’s the only place you have to live.”

— Jim Rohn

Here is an uncomfortable truth from the research: of all six faces, the physical dimension was mentioned least by senior leaders — yet everything else rests on it. Without energy, rest, nutrition and fitness, even the strongest choices, principles, thinking, empathy and purpose eventually erode. Burnout is not a badge of honour.

Why Physical matters

African leaders often work amid sharp contrasts: abundant community, spirit and opportunity alongside unreliable power, stretched healthcare and little personal time. Long commutes, power cuts that disrupt sleep, family obligations late into the night and constant problem-solving all drain the tank. You cannot pour from an empty cup.

The science is clear. Chronic sleep loss impairs thinking, emotional regulation and immunity. Poor nutrition and too little movement feed diseases such as diabetes, hypertension and heart disease. Stress without recovery leads to burnout, anxiety and depression. And teams quietly copy what their leaders model.

The Super-Cube® approach

The Physical face draws on wellness research (the Wheel of Wellness model) and on African traditions that honour the body as the temple of the spirit. It treats physical well-being as a leadership competency, not a lifestyle preference.

Physical practices enable the other faces. A well-rested leader makes better choices. A nourished leader thinks more clearly. An energised leader brings more patience to every conversation — and gives others permission to look after themselves too.

How it grows

This face grows through small, consistent habits that compound — not extreme regimes or crash diets — backed by norms that respect boundaries and leaders who go first.

Self-care is not selfish. It is strategic.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

The body as the vehicle

A young peacebuilding leader in the Democratic Republic of Congo is running on empty: eighteen-hour days, irregular meals, too little sleep and the constant adrenaline of post-conflict work. He is proud of his dedication. A simple energy audit shows him he is heading for collapse.

He starts with one micro-habit: ten minutes of morning sunlight and movement. He adds the digital sunset, then walking meetings. He becomes more present, more patient and more creative in his mediation work, and his team begins to adopt the habits too. “I thought self-care was for people who couldn’t handle the pressure,” he says. “It was the pressure-handling strategy I’d been missing. My body was not the enemy of my mission — it was the vehicle.”

A composite drawn from patterns observed across African organisations; names and details are illustrative.

Six practices

1 The Energy Audit ONE WEEK, THEN ONGOING

For seven days, rate your energy from 1 to 10 on waking, at midday and in the evening. Note which activities, foods, people and places drain or restore you. Look for the pattern, then redesign your week around it.

2 Three Micro-habits START WITH THREE, THEN BUILD

Morning: ten minutes of movement or sunlight before screens.

Midday: a five-minute breathing or stretching reset instead of another coffee or scroll; try the 4-7-8 breath (in for 4 seconds, hold for 7, out for 8). **Evening:** a “digital sunset” an hour before bed — no

screens, no work email. Protect sleep as the foundation of everything else.

3 Food as Fuel EVERY DAY

Shift from dieting to fuelling: vegetables, fruit, legumes, whole grains, nuts and lean protein. Celebrate the traditional foods that nourished our ancestors — millet, sorghum, leafy greens, beans and groundnuts. Cut back on sugar, processed food and excess caffeine. Drink water.

4 Movement as Medicine AT LEAST 150 MINUTES A WEEK

Find movement you enjoy: walking meetings, dancing, gardening, cycling. Break it into pieces — a twenty-minute walk at lunch, a weekend hike with family. Movement is not punishment for what you ate; it is a celebration of what your body can do.

5 Rest as Strategy DAILY, WEEKLY, YEARLY

Schedule rest as deliberately as meetings: seven to nine hours' sleep, one full day a week without work, and real annual leave. Where "hustle" is celebrated, normalise recovery. The leader who works eighteen-hour days is not a hero; they are a cautionary tale.

6 The Annual Health Check NON-NEGOTIABLE

Treat it as a board meeting with your most important stakeholder: your future self. Screen for hypertension, diabetes and stress-related conditions, and act early. If signs of anxiety, depression or burnout appear, seek professional support without shame. Mental health is health.

NOTES

WORKBOOK



Your Physical self-assessment

Rate each statement honestly from 1 (rarely true for me) to 10 (consistently true).

1	I keep steady energy through the day without relying on caffeine, sugar or adrenaline.	
2	I treat sleep, movement and nutrition as non-negotiable leadership practices.	
3	I recognise early signs of burnout or depletion and take corrective action.	
4	I model healthy boundaries and recovery for my team and organisation.	
5	I see my body as a leadership asset to steward with care, not a machine to exploit.	
6	I have a movement practice that I enjoy and maintain consistently.	
7	I eat in ways that fuel sustained energy and long-term health.	
8	I protect sleep and rest as strategic priorities, not luxuries.	
9	I seek professional medical and mental-health support when needed, without delay or shame.	
10	I feel physically vital, resilient and able to sustain high performance over the long term.	
Total (out of 100)		

80–100

Exceptional. You are a model for others.

60–79

Strong foundation. Use the practices to go further.

Below 60

Needs intentional development. Start with the Energy Audit and the three micro-habits.

Date: _____ Retake on day 30: _____

PRACTICE

Run the seven-day Energy Audit, starting tomorrow morning. On day eight, change one thing in your week based on what you find.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Set a “digital sunset” alarm for one hour before bed — and honour it tonight.

Measure and develop this face at super-cube.me · free baseline and growth report



CHAPTER 09 · FACE 6 OF 6

Spiritual

The purpose that transcends and sustains

“Example is not the main thing in influencing others. It is the only thing.”

— Albert Schweitzer

Why do you lead? What larger story are you part of? What will remain when your title, your achievements and even your name fade? The Spiritual face addresses these questions: purpose, meaning, transcendence and alignment with principles larger than the self.

In the research it emerged as a quiet but powerful force — expressed as faith, service, legacy or connection to something greater than the ego. It guards against cynicism, fuels perseverance and provides the “why” that sustains the “how”.

Why Spiritual matters

In a world obsessed with metrics, spiritual intelligence is often dismissed as soft or private. Yet many of history’s most enduring leaders — Nelson Mandela, Wangari Maathai, Mahatma Gandhi, Mother Teresa — drew their courage and moral clarity from a purpose larger than personal ambition. In Africa, where indigenous and faith traditions have sustained communities through colonisation, conflict and hardship, spiritual leadership is not foreign. It is native: we are links in a chain of those who came before, those who are here, and those yet to come.

Spiritual leadership in the Super-Cube® does not impose any religion or belief. It welcomes those whose purpose is rooted in faith, but requires only the willingness to ask the big questions, to align daily actions with a larger purpose, and to live by the answers that ring true.

The Super-Cube® approach

The Super-Cube® defines spiritual intelligence as the ability to understand deep rules — the principles that govern a meaningful life — and to live in harmony with them. Viktor Frankl’s *Man’s Search for Meaning* showed that purpose is not a luxury but a lifeline in the face of suffering. And Ubuntu itself is a spiritual practice: the recognition that our humanity is bound up in the humanity of others.

How it grows

This face grows through reflection, connection and alignment: making space for the big questions, cultivating a relationship with your source of meaning — faith, nature, community, legacy or the divine — and making daily choices that honour it.

Purpose is not a feeling. It is a practice.

ILLUSTRATIVE STORY

Purpose is a practice

In Ethiopia, a young social entrepreneur building a regenerative farming enterprise faces drought, funding delays, staff turnover and community scepticism. He is tempted to abandon the vision.

He writes his Legacy Letter and begins a daily connection practice rooted in his Orthodox Christian faith and his ancestors' relationship with the land. He names his purpose: "I farm not to feed stomachs alone, but to heal the relationship between people and the earth, and to leave the soil richer than I found it for my children's children." That clarity carries him through the hardest seasons, and in time the community becomes his co-creators. "The purpose was always there," he reflects. "The practices helped me remember it when setbacks made me forget."

A composite drawn from patterns observed across African organisations; names and details are illustrative.

Six practices

1 The Legacy Letter YEARLY, READ MONTHLY

Write a letter to yourself from someone fifty years in the future — a grandchild, a community member, a future leader. Describe the impact of your leadership. *What did you stand for? What did you build or heal? What legacy did you leave?* Read it every month, and adjust your course.

2 Daily Connection 10-20 MINUTES

Through prayer, meditation, nature, journaling or silence, create a daily ritual that connects you to meaning. Ask: *What am I in service of today?* This is not escape; it is recalibration.

3 Your Purpose Story PERSONAL AND ORGANISATIONAL

Write it in three sentences: *I lead because ... I believe that ... My contribution is ...* Share it with your team and invite them to do the same. Then craft an organisational purpose that goes beyond growth to name the human impact you seek. Revisit it every year.

4 Intergenerational Connection ONGOING

Listen to elders' stories — what they fought for, learnt and hope for. Mentor, and learn from, the young. You are a link in a chain, not the centre of the universe.

5 Service Beyond Your Role REGULARLY

Serve where there is no benefit to your career: volunteering, community work, mentoring outside your circle. It purifies motive and keeps you close to those you claim to serve.

6 Nature and Silence REGULAR IMMERSION

Spend time in a garden, the bush or by the ocean — without agenda or device. Many African traditions honour nature as a source of wisdom and renewal. In an always-on world, silence is a radical act.

NOTES

WORKBOOK



Your Spiritual self-assessment

Rate each statement honestly from 1 (rarely true for me) to 10 (consistently true).

1	I have a clear sense of purpose that guides my daily leadership and gives my work meaning.	
2	I regularly reflect on how my work contributes to something larger than myself and my organisation.	
3	I draw strength from practices that connect me to meaning (prayer, meditation, nature, service, ritual, community).	
4	I help others discover and articulate their own sense of purpose.	
5	I make decisions that honour both present needs and future generations.	
6	I feel peace and alignment because my actions are consistent with my deepest values and purpose.	
7	I engage with elders and youth to stay connected to the intergenerational chain.	
8	I serve beyond my professional role as a way of staying grounded and humble.	
9	I make space for silence, reflection and connection to the transcendent.	
10	I lead from service rather than ego, and feel the quiet joy of meaningful contribution.	
Total (out of 100)		

80–100

Exceptional. You are a model for others.

60–79

Strong foundation. Use the practices to go further.

Below 60

Needs intentional development. Start with your Purpose Story and Daily Connection.

Date: _____ Retake on day 30: _____

PRACTICE

Draft your three-sentence Purpose Story. Read it aloud to one person you trust and ask what rings true.

☐ **ONE THING TODAY**

Spend ten minutes in silence, without your phone, and ask: *What am I in service of?*

Measure and develop this face at super-cube.me · free baseline and growth report

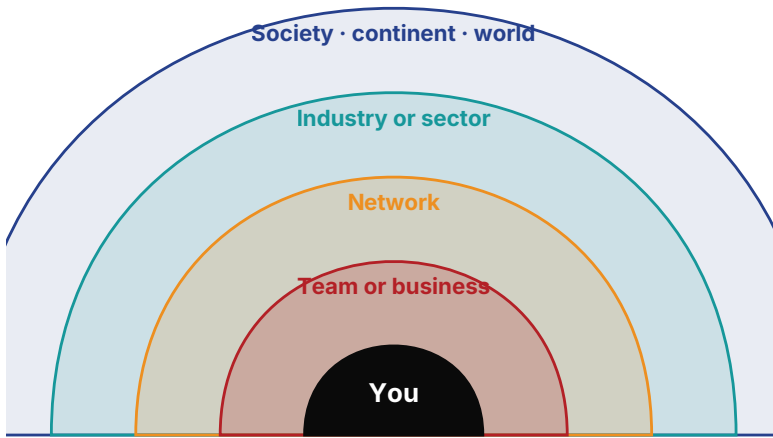


CHAPTER 10

From Self to Society

Scaling the Super-Cube® across levels

The true power of the Super-Cube® lies not in individual mastery alone, but in its scalability. Like a fractal, the pattern repeats at every level: individual, team, network, industry, society – and, ultimately, humanity.



The ripple: each Super-Cube® that is developed multiplies outward.

The original research mapped this progression within African business networks: from personal development plans built on the six faces, to leadership pipelines and culture in a single organisation, to cross-entity mentoring and shared standards across a network, to development extended to suppliers and partners in the supply chain, and finally to sector-wide capacity building.

Each Super-Cube® that is developed multiplies. One leader influences a team; the team influences an enterprise; the enterprise influences communities and economies.

What each level looks like

Individual — Your self-assessments, daily practices and Legacy Letter.

Team or business — A shared language of six faces; Dilemma Rehearsal, After-Action Reviews and psychological-safety norms; incentives and reviews aligned with principles.

Network — Cross-entity mentoring, shared standards, and development for suppliers and partners.

Industry or sector — Sector-wide capacity building.

Society, continent and world — Leadership taught from childhood, and leaders who serve the common good.

Measure the ripple

The ripple becomes visible when you measure it. Assess before you begin, practise deliberately, and assess again. That simple loop — rather than attendance or good intentions — is what produced the gains reported in Chapter 2.

Start young

Leadership does not begin with a job title. At **super-cube.me** anyone can start with a free baseline assessment, and Super-Cube® programmes for Kids (5–12), Adolescents (13–21) and Adults (22+) offer lifetime access for R99 — so a whole family, class or team can learn the same six faces together. See Resources and Next Steps.

PRACTICE

Draw five circles in your notebook — you, team, network, industry, society. In each, name one person or group you could influence with one Super-Cube® practice this month.

□ ONE THING TODAY

Share one practice from this book with your team, and try it together this week.



CHAPTER 11

Leaders for the Global Goals

Why the world's to-do list needs leaders, and why we must build them

In 2015, all 193 member states of the United Nations agreed on 17 Sustainable Development Goals: a shared plan to end poverty and hunger, give everyone health and a good education, achieve equality for women and girls, provide clean water and energy and decent work, protect the climate, the oceans and the land, and build peaceful, just societies, by 2030. Their promise is simple: *leave no one behind*.



The icons are the official UN Sustainable Development Goal icons, reproduced unaltered for informational purposes in line with the UN SDG Guidelines. The content of this publication has not been approved by the United Nations and does not reflect the views of the United Nations or its officials or Member States. See un.org/sustainabledevelopment.

Where we stand

The UN's latest report, *The Sustainable Development Goals Report 2026*, shows real progress, from wider access to electricity and clean water to more births attended by skilled health workers. But of the 139 targets that can be tracked, only 36 per cent are on track or making moderate progress. Nearly half are moving too slowly, and 15 per cent have gone backwards since 2015.

And the gaps are widest here. Seventy-one per cent of the world's extreme poor now live in sub-Saharan Africa. Only 68 per cent of the region's children complete primary school, and just 28 per cent finish

upper secondary. The UN says the prospects of ending extreme poverty depend largely on what happens in sub-Saharan Africa.

Source: UN DESA, The Sustainable Development Goals Report 2026.

Every goal needs leaders

Money, technology and policy matter. But none of them moves without people who lead. A clinic cuts maternal deaths because a manager keeps it stocked and safe. A girl stays in school because a principal notices she is missing. A town gets clean water because an official refuses a bribe. The Goals are won or lost in millions of such places, every day.

That is why the six faces matter. Here is how I connect them to the Goals. This mapping is my own, not part of the UN framework:

SIX FACES, SEVENTEEN GOALS · THE AUTHOR'S MAPPING



Choices

SDG



Responsible decisions for responsible consumption and production, and climate action.



Principles

SDG



Strong institutions: peace, justice, accountability and an end to corruption.



Mental

SDG



Learning and innovation for quality education and new industry.



Emotional

SDG



Partnership and inclusion: trust, gender equality and working together.



Physical

SDG



Health and well-being, starting with the leader and the team.



Spiritual

SDG

All 17

Purpose and vision: serving something larger than yourself, for generations.

One enabling goal

So here is my proposal, and it is mine, not the United Nations': **build leadership skills for everyone, at every level.** The UN has 17 Goals, not 18. Think of leadership skills development as the *enabling* goal underneath them, the foundation the other 17 stand on.

And it can be done. The research behind this book found that the six faces are recognised, connected and measurable. And in a twelve-week accredited Super-Cube® programme with leaders at Imana Foods and Kerry Foods, average assessment scores rose by 32.2 percentage points across the six faces (see Chapter 2). Leadership is not a gift for a few. It is a skill that can be built.

A call to action

The 2030 deadline is close, and the need for leaders will not end there. Here is what I am asking:

A CALL TO ACTION · BUILD LEADERSHIP SKILLS NOW

INDIVIDUALS

You

Take a six-face self-assessment this month. Pick your weakest face and practise it for twelve weeks. Choose one Goal and do one thing for it. Teach one skill to someone younger.

ORGANISATIONS

Organisations

Give every employee, not just a few, a development plan with a before and an after. Develop leaders in your supply chain. Report on leadership growth alongside sustainability.

SCHOOLS

Schools

Teach leadership as a learnable skill from the earliest years, across all six faces. Link projects to the Goals in your own community.

GOVERNMENTS

Governments

Recognise leadership skills in national qualifications. Invest in leaders closest to service delivery. Fund programmes that measure before and after, and publish the results.

The Sustainable Development Goals are the world's to-do list. Leadership is how the list gets done.

PRACTICE

Choose the one Goal closest to your heart. Which of your six faces would you need to grow to contribute more to it? Write down one practice from this book you will start this week.

☐ **ONE THING TODAY**

Share this call to action with one person, and agree one commitment you will make together.



CHAPTER 12

The Big Five Way

Real-world application across Africa

Theory is essential; application is everything. Big Five Group exists to *Feed. Educate. Empower.* The Super-Cube® is not a poster on the wall. It is designed to be the operating system for leadership across that mission — and it sits at the heart of **Big Five Learn**, the group's education division.

How the six faces show up

Big Five Agri — Regenerative farming training draws on *Mental* (systems thinking for climate-smart practice), *Physical* (farmer health and energy) and *Spiritual* (stewardship of the land for future generations).

Big Five Foods — Nutrition and school-meal work emphasises *Emotional* (connection with communities) and *Principles* (transparent, accountable delivery to the most vulnerable).

Big Five Connect — Finance and market access for youth agribusinesses build *Choices* (wise allocation of capital) and *Mental* (business-model innovation).

Big Five Learn — Super-Cube® leadership development integrates all six faces through blended learning, mentoring and on-the-ground practice, aligned to national qualifications frameworks, with online programmes for Kids, Adolescents and Adults at super-cube.me.

This is not charity. It is capacity building — leadership development that keeps giving for generations.

PRACTICE

Choose the one face your organisation's core work depends on most. Write down three ways to build it into how you train, measure and reward people.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Ask your team: "Which face does our organisation neglect most?" Listen for the pattern.



CHAPTER 13

Your Super-Cube[®] Action Plan

Start today, lead tomorrow

Knowledge without action is potential unrealised. Here is a practical 30-day roadmap to begin building your Super-Cube® today. Tick each step as you complete it.

WEEK 1 Awareness

- ☐ Take the free six-face baseline at super-cube.me, then complete the six self-assessments in Chapters 4–9.
- ☐ Identify your strongest and weakest faces.
- ☐ Write your Legacy Letter (Spiritual).
- ☐ Choose one micro-habit for each face.



WEEK 2 Foundations

- ☐ Use the Daily Pause and the Stakeholder Map for every significant decision (Choices).
- ☐ Complete your first Weekly Alignment Check (Principles).
- ☐ Run your first Weekly Systems Scan (Mental).



WEEK 3 Relationships

- ☐ Do the Empathy Walk with three different people (Emotional).
- ☐ Share your Super-Cube® journey with a trusted colleague and ask for feedback.
- ☐ Start one physical micro-habit with an accountability partner, such as a walking partner (Physical).



WEEK 4 Integration and momentum

- ☐ Retake the six self-assessments and compare your scores.
- ☐ Review all six faces and adjust your micro-habits.
- ☐ Introduce one team or community member to the Super-Cube®.
- ☐ Re-measure at super-cube.me and compare your before-and-after growth radar.

WORKBOOK · MY SUPER-CUBE® SCORECARD

FACE	DAY 1 (/100)	DAY 30 (/100)	MY MICRO-HABIT
 Choices			
 Principles			
 Mental			
 Emotional			
 Physical			
 Spiritual			

Keep going: the Super-Cube® circle

Leadership is not a solo sport. Form a Super-Cube® circle: a small group that meets monthly to share wins, struggles and accountability. Your journey accelerates when it is shared.

Beyond 30 days

Thirty days is a beginning. The leaders in Chapter 2 practised for twelve weeks, and every face grew. Keep going for twelve weeks, then measure again. And choose one of the Global Goals in Chapter 11 for your growing leadership to serve. A stronger face, put to work on a goal that matters, is how one person's growth becomes everyone's progress.

PRACTICE

Return to the sentence you wrote at the end of Chapter 1. Rewrite it in the light of your scorecard, and set a date, 90 days from today, to review it.

☐ ONE THING TODAY

Put your first Super-Cube® circle meeting in the diary, and invite two people.



EPILOGUE

A Super-Cube® World Awaits

Close your eyes for a moment. Imagine a world in which every leader operates from a balanced Super-Cube®.

Decisions are made with moral courage and strategic clarity. Teams thrive because leaders see them fully and inspire them deeply. Organisations pursue growth with principle, innovation with empathy and success with sustainability. Societies heal divisions because leaders model accountability and purpose. Humanity progresses because enough people have chosen to develop the full spectrum of their leadership.

This world is not a distant utopia. It is the sum of millions of individual choices — starting with yours.

The ripple becomes a wave

One Super-Cube® leader is powerful. A network of them can change the world. The Super-Cube® was designed to travel: human-centric and developable, it crosses borders. Adapt it. Translate it. The core remains: centred on *You*, balanced across six faces, radiating outward to teams, organisations, societies and humanity.

Africa will lead this wave — not because it must, but because it can. With the youngest population, some of the most urgent challenges and a model forged in its own experience, Africa is positioned to export not only resources but the leadership wisdom the world needs.

The Super-Cube® is not mine. It belongs to anyone willing to build it. Take it. Use it. Improve it. Share it.

From your growth to the Goals

Chapter 11 proposed leadership skills for everyone as the enabling goal beneath the 17 Sustainable Development Goals. Here is a thought experiment to show why. It is an illustration, not a forecast.

A THOUGHT EXPERIMENT · ILLUSTRATIVE, NOT A FORECAST

+32.2%

average rise in leadership assessment scores across all six faces after twelve weeks (Imana Foods and Kerry Foods intervention; percentage points, Chapter 2)

+45.1%

Principles

Strong, fair institutions
(Goals 16 and 10)

+39.5%

Emotional

Partnership and inclusion
(Goals 17 and 5)

+24.6%

Spiritual

Purpose that sustains all 17
Goals

Now imagine, purely as an illustration, that the clinic managers, teachers, farmers, buyers and public servants of one country grew their leadership by a similar margin. Nobody can put a number on what that would mean for the Goals in Chapter 11, and I will not invent one. But the direction is easy to picture: risks reported honestly instead of hidden, bribes refused, partnerships that hold when tested, teams that keep learning, and leaders who still care about the Goals after 2030. That is the enabling goal in practice: not an eighteenth Goal, but more capable people working on all seventeen.

The figures are percentage-point rises in average assessment scores in one programme. The extrapolation is a qualitative illustration, not a measured result or a projection.

START TODAY

super-cube.me

The evidence says leadership can be learnt. The Goals say it is needed everywhere, and soon. So here is what I am asking of you, in order.

1

Take the free assessment

Go to super-cube.me and take the free six-face baseline. It takes about ten minutes and shows you where to begin.

2

Start the programme

Choose Kids, Adolescents or Adults, work through the face courses and daily practices, then measure again and see your own before-and-after radar.

3

Bring it to others

Bring the Super-Cube® to your school, your team or your organisation: one shared model, one baseline, one cohort at a time.

GO DEEPER · THE COMPREHENSIVE EDITION

Leadership Is Learnable, the comprehensive edition of this book, goes much further: the research and evidence behind the model, each face in depth, and how to develop leaders at every level, from the classroom to the boardroom. It is available from late 2026 in print and e-book.

The challenges are real. The opportunity is historic. The time is now.

**Build your Super-Cube® . Accelerate leadership.
Progress humanity.**

Dr Craig R. Muller



Resources and Next Steps

RESOURCE · KEEP DEVELOPING ONLINE

super-cube.me

The model in this book is also a learning system. Measure your six faces, work on the weakest, measure again and see what changed: for one person, a class or a whole organisation.

Free baseline assessment

A free six-face baseline: about ten minutes, with a score for each face so you can see your strengths and gaps. No payment or card is needed.

Programmes for every age

Super-Cube® **Kids** (ages 5–12), **Adolescents** (13–21) and **Adults** (22+): the same six faces, with language, examples and practice matched to each stage of life.

Courses and practice

Six short courses, one for each face, a weekly practice plan that starts with your weakest faces, and a daily journal, check-in and micro-practices.

Re-measure, report, certificate

A second assessment, a before-and-after growth report with a growth radar like the one in Chapter 2, and a certificate with a public verify ID. Lifetime access costs R99, paid once, with no subscription.

Coaches, schools and organisations

A facilitator kit with an eight-week cohort calendar, coach tools with cohort codes, and seat packs for teams, schools and companies. Journals stay private; coaches see scores only when a learner consents.

Details as on the site in October 2026; check super-cube.me for current programmes and prices.

bigfivegroup.africa/leadership — Download this book free, and share the link with others.

bigfivegroup.africa — Big Five Group: *Feed. Educate. Empower.* Leadership training, partnership and implementation support through Big Five Learn.

Further reading and research

- Muller, C.R. (2020). Doctor of Business Administration thesis: the leadership skills development model behind Super-Cube®, a case study of an African FMCG business network. University of KwaZulu-Natal.
- Muller, C.R. & Pelser, T.G. (2022). A proposed leadership skills development model for African FMCG business-networks: Super-Cube®. *South African Journal of Economic and Management Sciences*.
- Muller, C.R. & Pelser, T.G. (2022). The leadership skills development model, tested in an African fast-moving consumer goods business network. *Journal of Contemporary Management*. doi.org/10.35683/jcm21092.154
- Buber, M. (1923/1970). *I and Thou*.
- Illeris, K. (2007). *How We Learn: Learning and Non-Learning in School and Beyond*.
- Mayer, J.D., Salovey, P. & Caruso, D.R. (2008). Emotional intelligence: New ability or eclectic traits? *American Psychologist*.
- Caldwell, C., Karri, R. & Vollmar, P. (2006). Principal theory and principle-based leadership. *Journal of Business Ethics*.
- Haidt, J. (2012). *The Righteous Mind: Why Good People Are Divided by Politics and Religion*.
- Kahneman, D. (2011). *Thinking, Fast and Slow*.
- Frankl, V.E. (1946). *Man's Search for Meaning*.
- Edmondson, A.C. (2018). *The Fearless Organization*.

Join the movement

Whether you lead a business, a classroom, a ministry or a household — or simply believe in Africa's potential and humanity's progress — there is a place for you. The future is not something we enter. It is something we create, one Super-Cube® at a time.

About the Author



Dr Craig Ross Muller is the creator of the Super-Cube® leadership model and the founder and chief executive of the Big Five Group, based in Pietermaritzburg, KwaZulu-Natal, South Africa.

The model in this book grew out of his Doctor of Business Administration at the University of KwaZulu-Natal: a thesis on leadership skills development, completed in December 2020 and conferred in 2021, built as a case study of an African FMCG business

network. He surveyed 132 people and interviewed ten directors to learn which leadership skills matter and how they can be developed, published the research in peer-reviewed journals in 2022, and has since seen the model taught in accredited programmes, including the intervention in Chapter 2.

He has spent more than twenty years in blue-chip FMCG, supply-chain optimisation and global consulting. He holds an MBA (2006, with a distinction for his dissertation on sub-Saharan vendor reliability) and a Postgraduate Diploma in Management (2004) from the University of KwaZulu-Natal, and a Bachelor of Commerce from the University of Natal (2002). His certifications include PMP, PRINCE2, Managing Successful Programmes and Lean Six Sigma Black Belt.

The Big Five Group's mission is three words: feed, educate, empower; Super-Cube® and Big Five Learn are how it educates. Craig's conviction, and the argument of this book, is that Africa's progress depends as much on the skills of its leaders as on its resources, and that those skills can be learnt by anyone, at any age.

Above all, Craig is the very proud father of Georgia and Benjamin, the apple of his eye. Much of this book was written with them in mind, and with every child of their generation: the hope that they will grow up knowing that leadership can be learnt, and that it is meant to be used for the good of others. His love for his children and his love for humanity are, in the end, the same commitment: to leave people better led, better fed and better able to build the future they want.

Georgia and Benjamin: may this work inspire you to do good, and to help humanity move forward.

super-cube.me

Free baseline; programmes for kids, teens and adults

bigfivegroup.africa

The Big Five Group: feed, educate, empower



Leadership is learnable — and Africa's future depends on it.

The Super-Cube® Leadership Model puts *you* at the centre of six developable faces of leadership: Choices, Principles, Mental, Emotional, Physical and Spiritual. Born from doctoral research at the University of KwaZulu-Natal and tested inside a real African business network, it is a practical, human-centric way to grow as a leader — and to grow the leaders around you.

- The six faces, explained simply
- 36 practices you can start this week
- Six self-assessment workbook pages
- A 30-day action plan
- One thing you can do today, in every chapter

Dr Craig R. Muller is the founder of Big Five Group — *Feed. Educate. Empower.* — and the creator of the Super-Cube® Leadership Model.

+32.2%

average improvement across the six faces in the 12-week Super-Cube® leadership intervention with Imana Foods and Kerry Foods



Choices



Principles



Mental



Emotional



Physical



Spiritual

Free digital edition · super-cube.me · bigfivegroup.africa/leadership

super  cube®